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THE SMALL CLUSTER OF HUTS IN SAIDAPET, TO THE WEST OF MADRAS, was waking up to the cacophony of ducks, some rushing to the pond for a morning bath and some already in the water. Ragothaman had parked his Jeep about 100 yards away. He didn't remind one of the conventional cop, but the arrival of his police Jeep alerted onlookers. And then faces started peeping out from inside the huts.

He stood in front of a hut and looked around, trying to ascertain if he was at the right address. He didn't want to raise an alarm. Nobody came out of the hut. After a while, he pushed open the door and entered. Inside, he saw two photo frames adorned with garlands—that of Haribabu and Rajiv Gandhi. Haribabu's elderly father figured the man must have come for something in connection with his dead son. He didn't dare ask Ragothaman who he was until the latter introduced himself. Haribabu's father asked him to sit and said he would be back soon with coffee. Ragothaman waved at him to sit and not bother about it.

Pointing to Haribabu's picture next to Rajiv's, Ragothaman asked if the young man was a Congress party worker.

'No, he was my son. A photographer by profession … died at the blast site.'

'I am so sorry to hear that. What was his name?'

'Haribabu.'

'Has his last rites been performed?'

Ragothaman noticed a young girl gaping at him from one side of the hut. The father introduced her as his daughter.

'We cremated the body after getting it back from the hospital.'

Haribabu's mother, Meenakshi, returned from some work outside. Haribabu's father used just one word to describe the guest to his wife: